



Frankfurt School

PEM Programmes

THESIS GUIDELINES

Intake 2024 / Class of 2026

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For all detailed information about the thesis please consult the General Examination Regulations for Academic Study Programmes (§8 Bachelor's and Master's Theses) and the Academic regulations for your degree programme (§8 Thesis). The written thesis corresponds to 18 ECTS (360 accumulation points). The thesis concludes the studies in Master degree program.

The aim of the thesis is to apply the qualifications acquired in the degree program to a specific problem. It involves the written processing of a relevant practical or theoretical-conceptual problem using scientific methods.

1 Timeline

For 3-semester track students:

Registration Deadline	Writing Period	Submission Deadline
I: 15 August 2025	September – October – November	30 November 2025
II: 15 September 2025	October – November – December	31 December 2025
III: 15 October 2025	November – December – January	31 January 2026

For 4-semester track students:

Registration Deadline	Writing Period	Submission Deadline
I: 15 January 2026	February – March – April	30 April 2026
II: 15 February 2026	March – April - May	31 May 2026
III: 15 March 2026	April – May – June	30 June 2026
IV: 15 April 2026	May – June – July	31 July 2026
V: 15 May 2026	June – July – August	31 August 2026

2 Selecting a topic

You may choose any topic area for the thesis as long as it is business-related and/or related to your programme of study. It may be a new topic or, alternatively, a topic worked on earlier in the programme which can be further developed. The topic is expected to be relevant to contemporary business and stretching in terms of academic thinking.

It is strongly recommended that you select a topic that is interesting and personally rewarding. You will need to sustain your motivation and enthusiasm throughout many long and difficult phases of the thesis. The start-point for finding a topic may be to try to answer some of the following questions:

- Is there a subject area that, if you were to become more of an expert in it, would enhance your career?
- Did you come across any theory or model during your programme that you found intriguing, challenging or you feel is highly appropriate for or relevant to your own business area?
- Is there an area of business practice that you feel is currently under-researched and there is scope for further investigation?
- Is there a managerial problem or issue relating to your job or organisation that you would find interesting to investigate?

An area of investigation is often still relatively vague at the beginning and only becomes more concrete during the more detailed examination of the topic. Experience has shown that topic development and structuring present a particular difficulty, because the first impression of a possible practical problem does not automatically provide a suitable topic for a scientific study in the necessary depth. Sometimes an empirical concretization is appropriate in addition to a theoretical penetration. A literature search is therefore essential at the beginning. It can help to better assess a subject area in terms of a conceivable scientific approach. Current references must be established in order to develop a possible focus for your own work.

As part of an initial exploration of the relevant literature, insights can be gained into key texts and relevant concepts of opinion-forming authors within the subject area. In the next step, the student's own topic is broken down into a question that can be investigated in the thesis.

3 How to write a thesis

3.1 Developing a research question

Whilst conducting the literature review and reading about the topic you will become acquainted with the key literature, leading authors, and main concepts within the topic. The next step is to refine the topic into a question which can be researched and answered within the scope of the thesis.

Example:

Your research topic might be "the impact of new training systems being introduced into an organisation".

Your specific question within this topic might be “Is there a relationship between employee training and employee commitment?”

It may take a little while to formulate your research question and it may be that you revise your research question many times throughout the process of writing your thesis. It should be constantly considered whilst reading the literature. There might be only one research question, although multiple questions are possible. The aim is to write the research question in one sentence. When developing both the topic and the specific research question the student should think about the feasibility. In particular, it is important to consider:

- Can I access data that will enable me to answer my research question?
- Do I have the skills and interest to pursue this work to completion?
- Does it solve a new problem or build on a pre-existing idea? Is it arguable?
- Is the scope manageable within the time limit and length constraints?

Please keep in mind that you should stay in contact with your assessors during the whole writing process. Try to update them on your progress and ask them if you are in doubt about something related to your thesis.

3.2 Writing of a thesis

The thesis can also be written in groups of two. Please note that a clear distinction must be made between the areas being worked on. We therefore ask you to complete the table “Contribution to group work” (Appendix 4) accordingly and attach it to the thesis. Please also note there whether you would like to be assessed individually or as a group.

Your thesis should consist of approximately 60 pages (exclusive of the title page, table of contents, other tables, references and/or appendices). The exact scope of each individual thesis has to be defined in accordance with the first assessor.

You need two assessors for your thesis. At least one assessor of them must be a member of the Frankfurt School Faculty or has to have the status of Scholarly Academic or Practice Academic at Frankfurt School. The other one can be external, but must provide evidence of holding a degree at least equivalent to a master’s degree when you submit your registration and proof an understanding of your thesis topic. Neither assessor can be a relative of yours nor a student /alumni who is/was enrolled at Frankfurt School at the same time you.

The topic of your thesis must be approved by both of your assessors. Within the first four weeks after registration, you may change your topic completely and/or your co-author.

The following table provides an overview of the responsibilities of students and assessors. However, this is merely a guide and not an exhaustive list. Key points of the supervisory

relationship should be agreed individually as it seems appropriate for the respective work and the persons involved.

<u>Responsibility of student(s)</u>	<u>Responsibility of assessor(s)</u>
<u>Begin</u> • Ascertainment of the subject area • Formulation of the problem to be investigated and the associated research question(s) • Consideration of suitable research methods and instruments • Initial overview of literature/work in the subject area (to be developed further in the course of the work) • If necessary, discussions with relevant practitioners in the subject area • Draft outline • Written outline of the subject area, the research objective and the choice of scientific methodology for processing as well as the proposed structure (in consultation with the reviewer informally as an e-mail or in another form, e.g. as an exposé)	<u>Begin</u> • Feedback on the student's suggestions • Ensuring that the student has chosen a scientifically and practically suitable question (depth and feasibility) • Agreement on the methods, the structure of the work and the timetable
<u>During writing period</u> • Continuation of the literature review and concretization of the methodological design • Structuring the individual chapters • If necessary, carry out the data collection for an empirical work • Comparing progress with the schedule • Gradual completion of the individual chapters • Contacting the assessor or by arrangement	<u>During writing period</u> • Answering any questions that arise and providing information for further processing • Requesting status reports if necessary • Meetings by arrangement
<u>At final stage</u>	<u>At final stage</u>

• Review of the individual chapters and the coherence of the work • Formulation of a (thesis-like) summary. • Check the connection between the question(s) raised in the problem statement and the individual sub-problems and highlight the individual partial solutions as well as the overall solution. • If necessary, clarification of open questions before submission.	• Final discussion before submitting the thesis, if applicable.
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4 Registration of a thesis

Students register their thesis on the SuSy Submission System. For more information, please review the SuSy UserGuide.

5 Thesis extension

The examination regulations allow an extension to the thesis submission deadline in situations where the student is not at fault. Legitimate reasons to apply for an extension of the deadline are only illness, good reasons and/or academic reasons. Please note that if a student hands in their thesis after the deadline without providing one of the below reasons, the thesis is deemed with 0 points / failed.

5.1 Illness

The days of sickness are counted for the extension accordingly. Meaning that if you were sick for six days, your submission deadline will be postponed by six days. If you are writing a joint thesis, the days of sickness is divided by the amount of authors. Meaning that if you were sick for six days, and you write in a group of two, your submission deadline is postponed by three days.

The form "inability to take an exam" has to be handed in within SuSy in the corresponding sick note upload (form is to be found in your Study Guide). The submission of the original sick note is not necessary. Please note that we will not accept any other sick note formats. The upload must take place within 3 working days after the exam date. Please name your document for the upload as follows: DateoftheexamDD.MM.YYYY_Titleoftheexam_YourLast,Firstname (for example: 22.10.2020_PrinciplesofFinance_Mustermann,Max).

5.2 Good reasons

If you are unable to proceed writing your thesis due to other good reasons, please upload the "Application to withdraw from the examination for good reason" in the SuSy sick note upload. The upload must take place within 3 working days after the exam date. Please check out the information sheet regarding good reasons provided in your Study Guide. Please name your document for the upload as follows:

DateoftheexamDD.MM.YYYY_Titleoftheexam_YourLast,Firstname

(for example: 22.10.2020_PrinciplesofFinance_Mustermann,Max).

5.3 Academic reasons

An extension to the thesis submission deadline for academic reasons requires a written request with a proposed timeline for completion and a justification from your assessor. An extension for academic reasons can only be approved once and only for up to four weeks. This request has to be made within SuSy no later than one week prior to the thesis due date and it has to be approved by your first assessor as well. An extension due to the student's workload is not possible.

Note: If an extension of the submission deadline results in students starting an additional semester, additional fees will be charged. Reference to the study contract.

6 Submission

The thesis is only accepted as one PDF document in SuSy. It is checked with a plagiarism software. Your thesis is not considered submitted until it is completely uploaded.

Your thesis must include a signed „Statement of Certification“ (Attachment 4). If applicable (e.g. you are writing your thesis in cooperation with a specific company), your thesis must include a signed "Confidentiality Clause" which is included (separately). Please note that FS does not sign external confidentiality clauses from companies.

If the thesis is not submitted on time (23:59PM), it is deemed to have been failed and will be assessed with 0 points. Students must then register the second attempt (in accordance with Section 11 (8) of the "General Provisions for Study and Examination Regulations of the Frankfurt School of Finance & Management") within a period of four weeks after notification of the grade.

6.1 Grading

Your assessors have six weeks to evaluate the thesis. The grade will be provided on your Transcript of Records. The evaluation can be viewed upon request as well. Please contact your study advisor.

Assessors receive an evaluation form via SuSy. At the same time, the reviewers will receive a plagiarism report after the upload. Your assessors have six weeks to evaluate the work. The grade will be displayed in SuSy and promptly shown on the Transcript of Records. You can also view the evaluation via SuSy.

7 Structure and formal aspects

7.1 Composition

Your thesis is to be structured as follows:

(1) **Cover Page**

The front cover of your thesis should include the following information: Master/Bachelor Thesis, title, and your official name (see attachment 1).

(2) **Title page**

The title page contains the title of the study programme, the title of the thesis, your official name and address, matriculation number, the date of submission and the names of your assessors. Title: Ensure that the title of your thesis is focused and captures the nature of the work. It should be grammatically correct and contain no spelling errors. The title of the thesis must be agreed upon with and approved by both of your assessors (see attachment 2) and the same title as the one registered in SuSy with.

(3) **Table of contents** (including page numbers)

The table of contents should be discussed with your primary assessor **before** you start writing the thesis. The table of contents should show a clear line regarding how you have developed your topic (see attachment 3).

(4) **List of abbreviations, tables and figures** (if applicable)

(5) **Text**

The main text is accompanied by an introduction and a conclusion or summary chapter. The introduction should give the reader an overview of motivation, focus, objectives, and structure of the thesis. In this part, the student is expected to analyze the current situation, elaborate a clear research question, structure the problem and state the objectives. Moreover, the student should describe the approach and the course of the research and how the analysis was conducted. The main text should deal with the problem, present solutions and results of the research. One or more chapters should

be devoted to the discussion and interpretation of the results. Specifically, the student should go back and make reference to the earlier literature review and present findings within the context of the original literature critique. The following questions should be answered: Do the findings fit with or contradict existing theory or evidence? Do the findings shed new light on the existing body of knowledge?

(6) Summary

The summary chapter is the final chapter of the thesis. The student summarizes the research question and the objectives and presents the conclusion and/or suggestions and/or advice for the implementation of the findings. In drawing conclusions, the student should make the reader aware of any limitations (e.g. sample size, accuracy of sample profile to the true population, research within one organization only) that may have an impact upon the conclusions being drawn. Recommendations are made for further research or enhancements to the research method applied. Any potential problems relating to reliability and validity have to be discussed.

(7) Appendix

The appendix includes important material, which support the thesis' comprehensibility. This includes specifically used interviews, interview sheets, meeting minutes, raw data of evaluations and analyses and so on. If required, the appendix can include additional tables (such as data tables of a statistic evaluation). The appendix is not part of the graded thesis (except for form, layout).

(8) Bibliography

Every written source used in the thesis has to be included in the bibliography. Therefore, the student has to list publications like monographs, papers in edited books or volumes, research papers in journals, but also articles from web sites, newspapers and the sources of figures and tables. The references have to be classified in alphabetical order and should follow the Harvard, alternatively APA or MLA, style of referencing (please discuss with your assessor).

(9) Statement of certification (see attachment 4)

(10) Confidentiality Clause (if applicable, separate document)

7.2 Format

Standard formatting requirements when using Microsoft Word:

Font size (text)	Times New Roman: 12pt., or Arial: 11 pt.
Font size (footnotes)	Times New Roman: 10pt., or Arial: 9 pt.
Line spacing	1.5 (after a paragraph: 9 pt. at least)
Left margin	4cm

Right margin	2cm
Number of pages	approx. 60 pages (single author) +/- 10% Please get in touch with your assessor.

8 Literature research

8.1 Basics of literature research

The starting point of every scientific paper is the study of existing and published literature. Depending on the focus of the work, the literature research plays a different role - but it is always a core component of the work. Even in the case of new and previously unexplored subject areas, it is important to conduct a literature review - for example, from the perspective of a related discipline or similar theories and concepts, to develop your own perspective on this basis.

The aim of the literature research is to analyze existing ideas and concepts regarding your own research question and to critically review them in terms of their degree of novelty. The student's own topic is embedded in the current state of science, or this is used as a starting point for their own applications, further developments or new formulations.

Starting from general research on the broader topic area, a focused literature search is carried out regarding the core topic and the student's own research question.

The literature used must be identified at the relevant points in the text. Only a literature source that has been included in the work in this way may be included in the bibliography. It is advisable to include the cited literature in footnotes. Alternatively, it is permissible to integrate it into the text. In both cases, a precise source citation is required that allows intersubjective traceability, usually down to the relevant page. The indication of the sources used serves on the one hand to ensure scientific honesty and on the other hand to show a profound engagement with the current scientific knowledge .

8.2 Relevant publications

Articles from renowned academic journals, monographs by leading scientists and, especially in the case of legal issues, relevant commentaries are essential for the literature search. They must be consulted in sufficient numbers to enable a reviewer to judge that the work meets academic standards.

Practice-orientated publications or online sources can be used as a supplement to show how the respective topic is discussed in practice and which perspectives are of particular importance here. However, they are not a substitute for academic sources.

The following questions should be considered, especially when using non-academic literature:

- What weight does the source have; is it appropriate to include it in an academic paper? Take into account that the significance of a source will have an impact on your own work and the arguments you have developed and could possibly weaken them.
- Who is the author of the article? What significance does he/she have for the subject area? What other texts has he/she written? Could the statement be drawn from another text with a higher scientific standard?
- What is the source of the material; is it reliable? Is the author recognizable?
- Is the article well structured? Are the arguments comprehensible and substantiated or are they mere platitudes?

8.3 Access to relevant literature

Initially, it often appears to be a challenge to find relevant literature for one's own subject area. As a rule, however, the actual problem lies in selecting the relevant contributions from many sources. In this respect, the acquisition and processing of relevant literature presents its own academic challenge.

The Frankfurt School library provides access to numerous relevant print media, e-books, journals, and databases. You can find access and explanations at: [Canvas](#) ▪ [Study Guide](#) ▪ [Campus & Facilities](#) ▪ [Learning Centre](#)

Access is also possible via Online Campus: [Online Campus](#) ▪ [Inform](#) ▪ [Library](#)

On the Learning Centre page, you will find the sections 'Library Catalogue', 'EBSCO Discovery Service (EDS)' and 'Databases'. The Discovery Service in particular, whose search bar can be seen in the image below, offers a good starting point for your literature search. With the help of the Discovery Service, you can search within the available book collection as well as access all our licensed journals at the same time.

EBSCO Discovery Service (EDS)

The EDS is an extensive research tool which includes all results from the Library catalogue but also includes resources from most of our literature databases - for example a huge collection of online journal articles.

Search all library content

Search

For a targeted search for printed books and e-books, we recommend the library catalogue, as it is updated in real time.

8.4 Databases

In the 'Databases' section, you can access the available literature databases as well as the fact databases. In principle, you can access our databases from home without any problems .

Databases

We offer access to literature databases and many important economic and financial databases.

Literature Databases

Factual Databases

Beck-Online is an exception for the literature databases. Please note that your initial registration with Beck-Online must take place on campus. Under 'Literature Databases -> Beck-Online' you will find the instructions for registering for the database.

The fact databases give you access to statistics as well as company, market and stock exchange data and other business-related information. The Bloomberg and Factset databases can only be used on special computers on campus.

You can find out which literature and fact databases you have access to, what they specifically contain and whether they require special registration in the Study Guide under 'Literature databases and fact databases'. The Study Guide also contains lots of other information, such as video tutorials on literature research and using library resources.

8.5 Referencing/Citations

Every direct or indirect quoting of a third party's ideas **MUST be referenced**. The style of citation should be discussed with the assessors. The standard is Harvard; however APA and MLA styles of referencing are also acceptable.

Generally, there are two possibilities for quotations. Either citations are attached directly at the end of a sentence or presented in a footnote. By using footnotes, the reader may focus on the text without being interrupted by citations. Footnotes are therefore the preferred option. If the first option (citation included in the text) is chosen, references are to be put short and the full

reference is given in the bibliography. The style of referencing being used (e.g. Harvard, APA or MLA) will determine what information, and order of presentation, will be included in the citation.

There is also a difference between direct and indirect quotes. Direct quotations literally state a third party's idea, whereas indirect quoting refers only to the idea, but it is described in your own words. The reference of indirect quotes is marked by the word "confer", abbreviated "cf." The direct quotes are put in between quotation marks.

EXAMPLE

Direct quotation: "What is globalization? It is a combination of internationalization, political and economic liberalization, and a technological revolution." (Woods, 2002:25)

Indirect quotation: The process of globalization combines internationalization and liberalization as well as a technological revolution. (cf. Woods, 2002:25)

Direct quotations are to be used only if needed, e.g. for definitions or in order to emphasize important facts or statements. It is important to mark any text taken from the literature by quotations, but it is also crucial not to stick too much to the literature. A consistent scheme of quoting throughout the thesis should be used in order to facilitate the reading.

Changing one or two words in a direct quote sentence or paragraph does NOT make it an indirect quote. As a rule of thumb, you can use the following: Whenever more than three words in a row are identical to the original source, you need to treat it as a direct quote (i.e., add quotation marks and page number).

The literature used should not be outdated, i.e. the student should take care that the latest editions of monographs, especially textbooks, are cited.

Again, the style of citation should be discussed with your assessors.

Attachments

Attachment 1: Template cover page

Thesis

Title

Subtitle (if applicable)

Vorname Nachname

Attachment 2: Template title page

Title of Thesis

Master's Thesis
at Frankfurt School of Finance & Management

Supervised by
First Assessor's Name
Second Assessor's Name

Submitted by
Your Full Official Name
Study program name and intake

Matriculation Number

Address

Telephone

Email

City, Month Year

Attachment 3: Choices of outline formats for Table of Contents

a) Numerical

1 Scientific Thesis

1.1 Different kinds of thesis

1.1.1 Exam papers

1.1.2 Scientific papers

1.1.3 Scientific monographs

1.1.4 Scientific reports

1.2 Different kinds of research

1.2.1 Literature-focused research

1.2.2 Empirical descriptive research

1.2.3 Theory grounding research

1.2.4 Theory scrutinizing research

1.2.5 Methodology research

2 Planning

2.1 Planning of time

2.2 Planning of resources

2.3 Planning of costs

b) Alpha-Numerical

A Scientific Thesis

I. Different kinds of thesis

a) Exam papers

b) Scientific papers

c) Scientific monographs

d) Scientific reports

II. Different kinds of research

- a) Literature-focused research
- b) Empirical descriptive research
- c) Theory grounding research
- d) Theory scrutinizing research
- e) Methodology research

B Planning

- I. Planning of time
- II. Planning of resources
- III. Planning of costs

Attachment 4: Statement of Certification _joint Thesis**Statement of Certification _joint Thesis**

We hereby confirm that the group work presented has been prepared independently according to the agreed work plan, using no other sources, resources and other aids than those mentioned. All parts – literally or by their meaning – taken from published or non-published sources are credited as such. The group work in its current or similar form has never been submitted as a graded assignment. Changes the work plan has been agreed upon with the first assessor.

City, Date

Authors' Signatures

Attachment 4: Statement of Certification _ solo Thesis**Statement of Certification _ solo Thesis**

I hereby confirm that this thesis constitutes my own work, produced without aid and support from persons and/or materials other than the ones listed. Quotation marks indicate direct language from another author. Appropriate credit is given where I have used ideas, expressions or text from another public or non-public source. The paper in this or similar form has never been submitted as an assessed piece of work in or outside of Germany. It also has not yet been published.

City, Date

Author's Signature

Attachment 6: Contribution Joint-Thesis

Thesis - Contribution to joint / group thesis work

Topic/Title:

Thesis writing period:

Submission date:

Name and Signature of Group Members	Responsible parts of the work according to agreement with the first assessor (clear delimitation of the contributions, e.g. by naming topics and/or chapters, sections, etc.)

☐ We agree to a joint evaluation of the work.

☐ We would like separate reviews for the individual group members.

Regardless of the choice made here by the students, the reviewers may grade the performance of the students equally if the contributions are of equal quality and give different grades if the quality of the contributions for which they are responsible is different.

Attachment 7: Assessment Criteria

	Not sufficient	Adequate	Outstanding
Problem description / Research objectives / Motivation of the research question	Objectives poorly defined or confusing Research objectives remain unclear Research question inappropriately motivated	Appropriate objectives Clear formulation (specification) of research objectives Research question properly motivated	Ambitious, clearly stated objectives Precise definition of research objectives Motivation for research question well-founded
Review of relevant scientific sources	Inadequate citation of literature	Summarizes relevant literature Uses appropriate literature sources	Critical analysis and summary of existing literature
Methodology / Research design and structure / Creativity	Inadequate choice of methods Inconsistent research design	Appropriate methodological approach Consistent research design	Comprehensible substantiation of methodology Creativity shapes the well designed research approach
Analysis /Evaluation / Discussion	Poor analysis and inconsistent evaluation of data or cases No original discussion of findings	Well documented analysis of data or cases Evaluation of research results and discussion of findings	Comprehensive analysis of the data or cases Focused evaluation of relevant findings Insightful discussion of results and consequences
Transfer / Conclusions and recommendations / Limitations	Limited and poor conclusions Trivial recommendations No discussion of limitations	Well articulated conclusions Recommendations consistently drawn from analysis Some discussion of limitations	Conclusions derive from analysis and literature Originality in the formulation of recommendations Comprehensive analysis of limitations and possible ways of overcoming them

Form / Style	Poor presentation with mistakes Bad writing style and structure Gaps in referencing and bibliography	Good writing style and structure Appropriate and consistent referencing	Clear structure throughout the thesis and rich writing style Excellent presentation, accurate referencing and bibliography
Overall quality	Purely descriptive, uncritical, no effective use of research methods, research questions not addressed	Focused on an appropriate research approach, leads to critical discussions of the subject and traceable conclusions, research questions addressed	Effective application of research methods; thesis provides independent analysis that demonstrates creativity, originality and deep insight in the subject/topic, all research questions fully addressed